

Photo Shot List

Guests decide in 3 seconds, and your first 5 photos do the selling. A bad photo kills a great room. A great photo saves an average room. Hire a pro, hand them this list, and then curate like you're building a hotel or resort listing. A pro with a plan beats a pro guessing.

Photographer Brief

Item	The number
Budget	\$300-\$1,000
Drone and twilight shots	Extra, on top of the base rate
Deliverable	A set of 30-50 photos
Listing gallery target	30-50 high-quality photos; volume builds trust

What a pro brings that your iPhone can't: proper lighting and angles, lifestyle vignettes (coffee mugs, a wine bottle, game night) that make guests picture themselves staying there, and both wide shots and detail shots.

Pre-Shoot Prep (Your Job, Before They Arrive)

- ☐ Declutter every surface
- ☐ Close the toilet lids
- ☐ Adjust the blinds for natural light
- ☐ Run the staging checklist: pillows styled, throws layered, rugs anchored, cords hidden, crisp bedding, table set, centerpiece styled, rolled towels, soaps, tray
- ☐ Turn on every light in the house
- ☐ Fire pit staged with at least 4 chairs
- ☐ Hot tub with jets on and cover visible (shows it works)
- ☐ String lights on at dusk. Huge for photos.
- ☐ Build lifestyle setups: wine on the patio, a s'mores kit at the fire pit, coffee mugs by the machine

The Shot List

Hero shots (your first 5 photo slots). The rule is simple: if you paid thousands for it, show it early, and put it in your title too.

- ☐ Your most expensive amenities: hot tub, sauna, fire pit
- ☐ Curb appeal or the exterior setting, especially if it's cozy, cabin-style, or scenic
- ☐ One strong interior moment: a styled living room or a fireplace

Room coverage (wide shot plus detail shot for each):

- ☐ Living room
- ☐ Every bedroom
- ☐ Dining area (table set for the full group)
- ☐ Kitchen (coffee station visible)
- ☐ Outdoor spaces

The 3-5 Instagram moments:

- ☐ The Welcome: front door, elegant lighting, clear entry
- ☐ The View or Unique Spot: hot tub overlooking nature, reading nook, outdoor shower
- ☐ The Gathering Spot: fire pit with real seating and string lights, or the covered porch
- ☐ The Bedroom Escape: layered bedding, good lighting, dreamy
- ☐ The Detail: welcome basket, stocked coffee station, local treats

Local connection:

- ☐ Include local photos (waterfalls, breweries, trail signs) to connect the listing to the experience

What to Cut

Curation is revenue. A listing we worked on in Greenville, South Carolina went live with about 90 photos and struggled from launch, roughly two bookings a month even with the new-listing boost working in its favor. Guests who opened it drowned in bathrooms, hallways, and close-ups of soap before they ever reached the money shots. We cut the photos that didn't need to exist, put one consistent look on everything that stayed, and led with the right shots for that market. The calendar went from two bookings a month toward 90% full. Depending on how bad the original listing is, the same home can go from \$3,000 a month to \$12,000 a month on presentation alone.

- ☐ Cut the bathroom overload (stage them well, show them once, move on)
- ☐ Cut the hallways
- ☐ Cut the soap close-ups
- ☐ Cut anything that doesn't need to exist
- ☐ Curate like a hotel or resort listing: show only what you want guests to see

Editing

You're not stuck with what the photographer hands you. If you don't love the edits, or the photos don't all share the same tint, a service like [photolab.teeco.co](https://www.photolab.teeco.co) can mass-edit your images to Airbnb quality. Full disclosure: photolab is the author's team's tool, built out of frustration with exactly that problem, so use it or any editor that gets the whole set consistent. Use the customize options to add people for lifestyle shots or swap in a beautiful sky, or keep the image original and just get the tint matched.

